

As a sacred mountain, Mount Fuji supplies a cultural ecosystem service for the people of Japan, while the surrounding rich volcanic soil provides a service to the local tea plantations.

“If current trends continue, humanity will dramatically alter virtually all of Earth’s remaining natural ecosystems within a few decades.”

Gretchen Daily

The four types of service

The MEA’s 2005 report detailed four categories of ecosystem services: supporting, provisioning, regulating, and cultural. Supporting services, such as soil formation and water purification, allow for the existence of all other services. Provisioning services consist of freshwater; food, such as crops and livestock; fibres, including wood, cotton, and other materials used for essentials such as building and clothing; and natural medicines, and plants used in pharmaceuticals. Regulating services include nature’s ability to control pests—as opposed to humans’ use of pesticides—and the atmosphere’s capacity to clean itself naturally, as well as the control of